

Shaping AI: Ethics, Power and Responsibility

ABSTRACT

This paper examines how AI is subtly shaped by racist undertones and perpetuates bias. It presents an overview of the roundtable Shaping AI, held in New Delhi in December 2025, which brought together community journalists to probe the overt and covert forms of racism they encounter in their professional lives and in their interactions with AI systems. The paper further explores how large language models can be shaped and trained to enable greater inclusivity and representation, while actively combating racial bias. By countering algorithmic silencing using listening and polyphonic systems, we can move towards more inclusive AI.

Keywords: artificial intelligence, bias, inclusive AI

INTRODUCTION

Imagine you're a young girl in rural Uttar Pradesh and your access to a smartphone is mediated entirely through your brother's phone. Your everyday life is shaped by entrenched gendered bias and explicit prohibitions from local power authorities known as *khap panchayats* that restrict the use of phones for girls. You encounter racism daily but have no safe spaces to process your experiences with this systemic issue. Meanwhile, your urban, formally educated peers not only use smartphones but engage with AI tools with ease, thus shaping who gets access to new technologies.

In a world where the rise of AI tools has meant that there are millions of people using AI to learn, upskill or pivot their careers or lives, the burdens of caste, gender and geographic location mean that being excluded from this and similar emerging technologies is a lived reality for many. While AI has the potential to democratise storytelling, existing social hierarchies are also reproduced and intensified through unequal access and representation to digital technologies and shaping the underlying data that drives them.



Figure 1: Participants gathered for the roundtable discussion

Racism, an inherent part of societal structures and cultures, including design, also risks getting reflected in AI tools which may unintentionally perpetuate these biases. As Sasha Costanza-Chock argues, universalist design practices tend to erase intersectionally disadvantaged groups by

assuming a ‘neutral’ user that does not exist (Costanza-Chock 2018). In fact, a 2024 study published in Nature found that AI language models discriminate between people based on their dialects, as they mirror known human prejudices (Hofmann et al. 2024).

This study examines a two-day roundtable in Delhi, held on 2–3 December 2025, that sought to address these challenges. The event was a collaborative initiative supported by the Goethe-Institut New Delhi, India, The Federal Agency for Civic Education (BpB) in Germany and an AI platform.

The roundtable’s central aim was to identify how racism impacts AI participation in India, and how AI systems reinforce existing biases, alongside developing mitigating strategies for equal access to AI. By using the roundtable as a focal point, this paper argues for polyphonic, dialogic and context-sensitive AI systems as the need of the hour.

Structural Barriers and Societal Challenges in Indian Society

The roundtable featured 16 journalists from community media organizations like Chambal Media and Video Volunteers, with many representing marginalized communities themselves. Both these organisations work to empower community voices within journalism. These journalists were chosen for their engagement with rural, underrepresented populations in Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and other states across the country. Participants highlighted entrenched gender, caste, and class hierarchies that hinder access to AI technology, in the rural hinterlands of India.

During the roundtable, participants shared common experiences which included constrained access to mobile devices and the internet for women, often controlled by male members of the family. They also discussed that women and marginalized individuals faced negative social perceptions for engaging with technology, often being told that their pictures would get “morphed” and misused by AI tools. This would further exacerbate fears around AI, thus leading to self-limited exposure to emerging tech.

In a vicious disruptive cycle, these constraints lead to rural and underserved communities being further excluded from AI and wealthy, urbane and largely Global North tech organisations gaining unfair and unequal narrative control on representation. In fact, as LLMs did not have much Icelandic data, the government of Iceland decided the best option

was to give OpenAI extensive Icelandic language resources to improve model accuracy (Schiffrin n.d.).

These exclusions are not merely a matter of access but of voice – who gets silenced and who is heard within big tech systems. Dominant, western-centric data is in fact, a form of systemic injustice which legitimises certain cultures and voices while suppressing others. The subtheme of *Silencing* for this conference is very much relevant here. In the case of AI, silencing operates at multiple levels – absence of training datasets, lack of access to AI tools and lack of linguistic representation. While big tech incorporates more languages into its AI systems, these systems are often not adequately trained on diverse languages, leading to incorrect responses. This leads to entire communities being erased or misrepresented within AI systems.

As a diverse population, India has various linguistic, social and cultural groups which are unrepresented or misrepresented or simply ignored entirely in AI training data, with the looming threat of erasure. As AI gets more fluent in dominant languages and power structures, the generated content fails to represent these rural communities. As successive Large Language Models (LLMs) are trained on these biased foundational datasets, bias is recursively accumulated, progressively amplifying and entrenching systemic inequalities over time. As Chen et al. argue, “If the data used to train the model are not representative of the population, or if certain groups are underrepresented or excluded in the data, then biases are likely to exist in the collection and preparation of the data” (Chen et al. 2023).

To address these gaps, the roundtable aimed to expand participation in AI development by amplifying underrepresented voices in AI storytelling. Participants were invited to actively shape the direction, insights, and design of AI training processes, grounding these interventions in the lived realities of gender- and caste-based discrimination in order to confront systemic exclusion and contribute to the creation of more culturally attuned datasets.

ROUNDTABLE DESIGN AND METHODOLOGY

As the roundtable foregrounded community participation and interrogated the complex dynamics of racism embedded within technological systems, it adopted a community-centred, participatory methodology. Journalists from

two rural media organisations were brought together to exchange experiences grounded in their local contexts. Participants were introduced to AI tools for creative practice and critically exposed to the ways in which AI training data can be exclusionary or biased. This need was further underscored by a Thomson Reuters Foundation survey indicating that 57.6% of journalists are self-taught in AI, highlighting a significant gap in structured AI training (Radcliffe 2025).

When even urban journalists in the Global Majority lack access to meaningful AI training, the idea that such knowledge will organically trickle down to rural newsrooms is an illusion. The roundtable's engagement with underrepresented populations was intentional in tackling this nonlinear knowledge diffusion of AI technology.

We structured the roundtable into the following key activities:

- **Story Sharing and Reflection Sessions:** The participants shared their experiences of caste, gender and class-based racism and how covert racism reflects in their professional lives.
- **Digging Deeper, Huddles, and Blue-Sky Speculations on AI Futures:** These deep-dives allowed participants to explore how racism manifests in AI systems and what kind of strategies are needed to design more inclusive, context-aware AI tools.
- **Hands-on Practices with the Model Image and Video Trainer Tools:** The AI platform had created a Model Image Trainer Tool as well as a Video Generation tool. To create more equitable access to tech and to solve the language barrier, an AI agent was created which participants could use to speak in Hindi and generate prompts for the tools in English. Using the AI tools, participants trained their model trainer in their unique, aesthetic styles, thus experimenting with narrative generation and image and video creation. The digital interventions confronted UX challenges for non-English speakers and instilled confidence in them about AI.



Figure 2: Participants noting down their thoughts during a group exercise

- **Peer Learning and Support:** We devised the roundtable in a way that participants could form cross-sector networks and connect beyond the project as well. This was meant to sustain collaboration and community-driven AI development. The roundtable imagined participants as co-creators of shared AI tools.
- **An AI Curriculum for Journalists:** In order to bridge the data divide between AI users and rural communities with no access to AI, we used methods like reverse ideations and core huddles to create an AI curriculum for journalists from marginalised communities.

Polyphonic AI

These practices can be understood through the lens of polyphony and dialogism, as conceptualised by Mikhail Bakhtin. A polyphonic AI system includes multiple models, voices and perspectives rather than a single, overarching system. We designed several different tools for this roundtable, each uniquely tailored to participant needs. We used image trainers, video generation model trainers and an AI agent to help participants speak in Hindi and generate prompts for the image trainer. This AI agent was specially designed for the linguistic needs of the participants and Hindi-speaking cohort.

Our tools fostered interaction rather than a single, controlled mechanism and were dialogic and conversational. Thus, one could tailor their approach to AI systems in a polyphonic way. Applying Bakhtin's idea of polyphony and dialogism to AI can result in more democratic AI. Our Image trainer tools, for example, were first trained on participant datasets, thus creating a unique AI model for each participant. Then, this model was used to further generate datasets. We also allowed for zero data retention, thus upholding privacy and safety of participants.

The tools developed for the roundtable can be understood as anti-silencing interventions. The idea was to distribute control, authorship and participation across the cohort rather than reliance on a single, centralised system. Unlike conventional AI models that operate through centralised systems and employ dominant datasets, these tools were shaped through ongoing interaction with the participants, allowing them to actively influence both inputs and outputs. This shift from control to engagement enabled more plural and inclusive ways to interact with AI systems, thus ensuring that participant fears around AI could also be assuaged.

By facilitating multiple points of engagement, the tools disrupted the idea of a single authoritative system. Participants were able to generate and train their own image models using personalised datasets, resulting in multiple, unique outputs rather than a homogenised representation of what their culture looks like. This approach fostered a collaborative ecosystem of knowledge production.

Such a model supports greater diversity in representation, as it allows for a range of perspectives, aesthetics, and narratives to emerge simultaneously. In doing so, it challenges the silencing effects of dominant AI systems by big tech and opens up space for more equitable and context-sensitive forms of engagement.

Participant Experiences

Several participants highlighted the importance of creating safe learning environments for AI like the Shaping AI roundtable, which was a critical step towards a more inclusive, anti-racist AI designed in participatory ways. Participants saw value in further expanding the roundtable into a fellowship that would include more rural participants and journalists, and include scaffolded learning methods to ease their pathway towards creating and using AI tools.

“We could make AI better by providing a space to learn safely while still protecting personal art and its equivalent. It shifts power as creators and communities get to decide how to share and protect their culture and stories.” — Participant

Others drew attention to the representation gap within AI ecosystems, particularly for organizations like Chambal Media working at the intersections of gender, caste, and class.

“As an organization which works with marginalized communities, and understands gender, caste, class in a much deeper way, we feel a huge gap when it comes to AI. The targeted audiences are also very different. What we need in this technology space is to make it more inclusive and to have more representation.” — Participant

RECOMMENDATIONS FROM THE ROUNDTABLE

The imbalance within AI is not incidental but a structural flaw from bias in training data and non-inclusive systems and infrastructures design. As Dr. Katelyn Jones observes: *95 percent of images used to train AI models*

depict white skin, while medical algorithms often draw on U.S. military datasets in which women may constitute only six percent of subjects (Jones and Mattea 2020). The recommendations from this roundtable are conceptual and grounded in practice and lived experience.

The AI Now Institute notes, “claims of objectivity and neutrality in AI systems often mask underlying power relations and systemic biases embedded in the data and the institutions that produce it” (West, Whittaker, and Crawford 2019). This shocking statistic highlights what we have known all this while: data merely masquerades as objective while being riddled with biases. The centrality of community and creative participation thus becomes paramount and this roundtable was a small but important step towards that process. From the learnings at the roundtable, we gleaned the following recommendations:

- **Establishing a Safe Context for AI Training for Journalists from Rural Communities:** It is imperative to create safe and financially supported spaces for women and other journalists from marginalised communities to experiment with AI and express themselves creatively. Our roundtable provided a space to a cohort of journalists to create images and videos in their creative styles, centering their everyday experiences and cultural contexts.



Figure 3: Cultural and context-aware outputs from the AI model image trainer - a contemporary Mughal-miniature style depiction of women on a motorbike and a journalistic avatar

- **Anti-Racist AI Practices:** The roundtable delved deep into the question of what constitutes an anti-racist AI. Can an AI which is shaped by the biases of

contemporary society be changed and made anti-racist by formulating legal frameworks? Or do we need different kinds of AI systems, which are the “utopian” versions of present AI from big tech? How can underrepresented voices be empowered in AI participation so that present-day AI is trained better and we also work towards an inclusive, sustainable AI for good? As Dancy and Saucier contend, focusing merely on bias in AI is insufficient and we must move towards examining the “design, development and deployment of AI systems” and cultures (Dancy and Saucier 2021).

- An anti-racist AI would reflect linguistic and cultural diversity and prevent cultural misappropriation. During the roundtable, participants observed how they could find stereotypes about their region, and gender in AI generated news content.
- **Capacity Building Exercises for Digital Confidence:** The hands-on exercises with the AI tools demonstrated that participants could build AI confidence even without prior knowledge of AI. For this, we need tools which are tailored for different contexts. By creating an AI agent for Image Prompting, the AI platform helped non-English speakers use the tools with ease.
- **Mitigating Biases in AI Systems through AI Literacy:** The roundtable showed that learning AI enabled storytelling allowed participants to engage more closely with algorithmic biases and relate them with their lived experiences. This turned their focus towards developing mitigating strategies like an AI curriculum for their peers and brainstorming on ethical frameworks for AI. Participants also viewed AI through a feminist lens, noting how it has stereotypes about what Indian women should look like. An AI generated image of an Indian woman had long dark hair, was clad in a kurta set and wore a bindi. Participants who were dressed differently from this AI representation and in varied ways understood the importance of creating AI images rooted in their personal and cultural narratives.
- **Tool Iterations and Ethical Frameworks for an Inclusive AI:** The Model Image Trainer is designed in a way that it can be iterated with participant feedback. Following the roundtable, participant feedback was incorporated into subsequent iterations of the image trainer tool; turning it into an AI agent deployed on WhatsApp. The roundtable also brought fresh perspectives on ethical frameworks for safe and practical engagement with AI, like ensuring data privacy, attribution, and culturally sensitive use of AI outputs.
- **Context Specific, Dialogic AI systems:** To respond to linguistic, social and cultural realities, it is necessary to design multimodal, dialogic AI systems which are context-specific. Participants in our roundtable were able to operate as interactive partners and design their own AI image trainers, which generated unique datasets in their own styles.

CONCLUDING REMARKS

The Shaping AI roundtable unearthed how AI surfaces racist stereotypes and linked it to everyday realities of gender and caste-based discrimination. It demonstrated how inclusive AI design needs to be intentional and participatory. While big tech firms use training data for fine-tuning their AI models, they do not collaborate with marginalized communities to truly erase biases or minimize them. This gap opens up the possibilities for open-source models which can be developed to be more culturally sensitive and nuanced through greater collaboration and transparency.

The roundtable highlighted how listening as a critical practice can counter the algorithmic silencing being done by AI systems to underrepresented communities. By incorporating lived experiences, multiple situated knowledge and aesthetic forms of expressions (image/video datasets), the roundtable foregrounded reciprocity, participation and collaboration. It was structured as a site for collective listening, where participants could share personal recollections and stories. As compared to an extractive model of AI development, a listening and practice-based approach lends itself to a more inclusive AI.

“Designing for ethical and inclusive AI refers to the intentional incorporation of human worth, autonomy, and identity into the fabric of AI systems” (Jain 2025). This roundtable showed that with intent, organisations can create spaces for pilot projects and training for AI, center lived experiences and reflect diverse cultural perspectives in AI.

Algorithmic bias is often treated as a technical issue of data composition; however, it may also be understood as a sociocultural phenomenon shaped by historically embedded structural inequalities. To fight bias and racism in AI systems, multi-perspective, polyphonic voices must be brought into the fold of these systems. Drawing from Bakhtin’s idea of polyphony, in the context of AI “these principles emphasise the multiplicity of perspectives and the dynamic, dialogic interplay of various subjective consciousnesses, reflecting the inherent diversity of human thought.” (Karimova 2024)

Critics may argue that an AI agent may not truly listen. But, it has been observed that single-point AI agents and systems too, tailor their answers based on prompts. The idea is to expand the training data to be representative of diverse voices – to truly build a “dialogue partner” rather than an “oracle of plausible responses”. (Schulbaum 2025)

This approach suggests that AI is not simply neutral but can function as a space for multiple, coexisting voices. The use of multiple, context-specific tools, such as the image and video trainers developed for this roundtable, reflects a more decentralised approach to AI systems. When scaled, such approaches have the potential to support greater plurality and more democratic forms of engagement with AI.

To commit to an AI that is inclusive, anti-racist and equitable for all, organisations and policymakers need long-term community engagement. So that one day, a girl from a marginalized community in rural Uttar Pradesh can create an AI news anchor in her likeness rather than a white one, to report stories from her region, in her voice.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The authors would like to thank Dev Aggarwal, Co-founder and CTO at Gooley.AI, for his invaluable technical guidance throughout this project. We are also grateful to Computational Mama, Head of Developer Relations at Gooley.AI, for her technical expertise and contributions. Finally, we sincerely acknowledge our project partners, the Goethe-Institut and the German Federal Agency for Civic Education (bpb), whose collaboration and support made this research possible.

DISCLAIMER ON THE USE OF AI

AI was used in the data collection for the roundtable. Participants created image and video datasets using AI tools. AI was also used for helping in formatting the paper, and language check. The paper is an original submission, free from ethical and plagiarism issues.

REFERENCES

- Chen, You, Ellen Wright Clayton, Laurie Lovett Novak, Shilo Anders, and Bradley Malin. 2023. "Human-Centered Design to Address Biases in Artificial Intelligence." *Journal of Medical Internet Research* 25.
- Costanza-Chock, Sasha. 2018. "Design Justice, A.I., and Escape from the Matrix of Domination." *Journal of Design and Science*, no. 3. MIT Press.
<https://jods.mitpress.mit.edu/pub/costanza-chock/release/4>.

- Dancy, Christopher L., and P. Khalil Saucier. 2021. "AI and Blackness: Toward Moving Beyond Bias and Representation." *IEEE Transactions on Technology and Society*, 1–1. <https://doi.org/10.1109/TTS.2021.3125998>.
- Hofmann, Valentin, Pratyusha Ria Kalluri, Dan Jurafsky, et al. 2024. "AI Generates Covertly Racist Decisions about People Based on Their Dialects." *Nature* 633: 147–154. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-024-07856-5>.
- Karimova, Aygul. 2024. "Polyphony in AI: Towards Dialogic and Multiperspectival Systems." *International Journal of Human–Computer Interaction*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10447318.2024.2338661>.
- Jain, Anushree. 2025. "Designing for Ethical and Inclusive AI through a Human-Centered Design Lens." *Global Business & Economics Journal*, June 5, 2025. <https://gbej.org/articles/designing-for-ethical-and-inclusive-ai-through-a-human-centered-design-lens/>.
- Jones, Katelyn, and Nicole Mattea. 2020. "We Need a Feminist Approach to AI Development." *Women in International Security (WIIS Global)*, June 5, 2020. <https://wiisglobal.org/we-need-a-feminist-approach-to-ai-development/>.
- Platoniq. 2025. "Oracle or Dialogue Partner? Towards a Polyphonic AI Dialogue." *Wilder Journal*. <https://journal.platoniq.net/en/wilder-journal-2/deep-dives/AI-dialogue/>.
- Radcliffe, Damian. 2025. *Journalism in the AI Era: Opportunities and Challenges in the Global South and Emerging Economies*. Thomson Reuters Foundation Insights Report. <https://www.trust.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/TRF-Insights-Journalism-in-the-AI-Era.pdf>.
- Schiffrin, Anya. n.d. "AI and the Future of Journalism: An Issue Brief for Stakeholders." In *World Trends in Freedom of Expression and Media Development*. UNESCO.
- West, Sarah Myers, Meredith Whittaker, and Kate Crawford. 2019. *Discriminating Systems: Gender, Race, and Power in AI*. AI Now Institute. <https://ainowinstitute.org/publications/discriminating-systems-gender-race-and-power-in-ai-2>.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR(S)